A GGCE LAGOS 2026 DIGITAL PUBLICATION

# THE MILLION NAIRA OPPORTUNITY

*How Nigerians can earn from the gold, gemstone and jewellery economy, with or without owning a mine*




YOUR PRACTICAL GUIDE TO OPPORTUNITIES IN NIGERIA'S MINING, GOLD, GEMSTONE AND JEWELLERY INDUSTRY

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# The Million Naira Opportunity

*The gold, the gemstones and the jewellery economy beneath our feet, and how ordinary Nigerians can earn from it*

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A GGCE Lagos 2026 Digital Publication
Prepared November 2026

# A Note to the Reader

This book was prepared in November 2026 for the Gold & Gemstone Conference & Exhibition (GGCE) in Lagos. It is a gift to readers who are tired of waiting for the economy to improve and are willing to look in a direction most of us have never looked.

Before you begin, four honest statements.

**The title describes scale, not a promise.** "Million Naira" points to the size of the commercial opportunity that exists across this industry. It is not a guarantee that you will earn ₦1 million or any other sum. Some readers will earn nothing, because they will read, decide the industry is not for them, and save themselves a costly mistake. That is also a good outcome.

**The facts are sourced.** Every statistic and every statement about the law in these pages comes from a public source listed at the end, and is attributed in the text. Where a reliable figure does not exist, the book says so instead of guessing. You will find that this makes some chapters more cautious than the usual advertising for this industry. It is deliberate.

**Some people in these pages are composites.** Where a story helps, I have invented a person to carry it, and I say so each time. They are illustrations of common situations, not real individuals, and any resemblance to a particular person is accidental. Every figure, law and event, by contrast, is real and sourced.

**This is education, not advice.** Nothing here is legal, tax, financial or investment advice, or an offer to sell you any investment. Licence fees, durations, tax thresholds and procedures change, so confirm current rules with the authorities named in Chapter 11 before you act.

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PROLOGUE

# The Question We Are Not Asking

Picture a woman I will call Amaka. She is not a real person. She is a composite of the many Nigerians who describe their situations in almost exactly the same words.

Amaka is thirty-four. She has a degree, a small business and a calculator that she has used more in the last two years than in the previous ten. Every month she does the same sum. What the market charged last month. What it charges this month. What her customers can still afford. What is left. The answer has been shrinking for a long time, and she is no longer surprised by it. She is only tired.

If you are reading this, you know Amaka. You may be Amaka.

## The crunch is real

Nigerians do not need a statistician to tell them that life has become harder, but the numbers confirm what the markets have been saying. In October 2024, the National Bureau of Statistics put headline inflation at 33.88%. By September 2026 it had fallen to 14.63%, which is real progress. But a falling rate of inflation is not a falling price. It means prices are rising more slowly, on top of the heights they have already reached. When inflation eased to 16.05% in October 2025, analysts were careful to add that Nigerians continue to struggle with high living costs, and anyone who shops for food will know why.

When people are squeezed, they look for relief. They look for a second income, a side business, a new skill, a way to earn in a currency that holds its value better than the naira has. Some look abroad. Some look to technology. Most look at the same few doors: trading, transport, fashion, food, and the digital hustle.

Almost nobody looks down.

## The black gold we cannot stop staring at

For most of our modern history, Nigeria has looked at one resource. We call it black gold, and the name is earned. Crude oil has been the country's largest source of foreign exchange and, for years, its largest source of government revenue. Even as its share has fallen in recent years, the National Bureau of Statistics records crude still accounting for more than half of all exports in the first half of 2025. Oil shapes our budgets, our exchange rate, our politics and our dinner-table conversations. When it does well, we hope. When it does badly, we worry.

The habit of staring at one resource has a cost, and it is the subject of this book. While the whole country watches the oil, we walk past everything else. The gold in the ground of Kebbi, Zamfara, Kaduna, Niger and Osun. The tourmaline of Oyo and Kwara. The sapphires of Taraba. The topaz, garnet and amethyst of the Jos Plateau. The tin and columbite that built a mining economy before the first barrel was ever exported. The women who have worked these mines and markets for generations, mostly unrecorded, mostly unrewarded.

None of this is secret. It is in geological surveys and government policy papers and the annual reports of institutions most Nigerians have never read. It is simply not part of how we think about money.

## What this book is, and is not

I want to be honest with you from the first page, because the industry I am about to describe has plenty of people who will not be.

This is not a get-rich-quick book. Mining is regulated. Gold and gemstone trading attracts fraud. The sector is small relative to its potential, and its potential is not the same as your income. Anyone who tells you that you can walk into this industry with a few thousand naira and walk out a millionaire is selling something.

What I can offer is more useful: a clear map. Where the money is made. Which doors are open to ordinary people, which are locked, and what the keys cost. What the law requires. What can go wrong. And what a sensible person might do in the first ninety days to find out whether this industry has a place for her.

## Three claims

The book makes three claims, and I will try to earn each one.

**First, Nigeria once had a real mining economy and let it fade.** Tin, columbite and coal were major industries before oil, and the sector's share of the economy has collapsed since. That is a story about choices, not geology, and choices can change.

**Second, the part of this industry that is open to ordinary people is larger than most Nigerians assume.** You do not have to own a mine. The chain from rough stone to finished jewellery is long, and most of its links are held by makers, traders, designers and service providers.

**Third, the road in runs through knowledge, rules and people.** You need to understand how the industry works, follow the law, and meet the people already in it. Among those people, women have been walking this road the longest, and they deserve a chapter of their own.

Amaka is going to learn all of this over the next thirteen chapters, and so will you. Let us begin where every honest account of Nigerian mining must begin: with what we used to have.

PART I

# The Case

CHAPTER 1

# The Forgotten Economy

*Before there was black gold, there was tin, columbite and coal*

Imagine standing on the Jos Plateau a little over a century ago. The air is cooler than on the coast. The ground, though, tells a different story. It is scarred with pits and stained with washings, and the sound of work carries across it: shovels, sluices, the clatter of ore being carried to a railway that did not exist a few years earlier.

This was the start of the story most Nigerians have never been told.

## How organised mining began

The history of organised mining in Nigeria begins in 1903, when the colonial government set up the Mineral Survey of the Northern Protectorates. Tin mining on the Jos Plateau followed, with Britannica placing its beginning in 1905. The sums grew quickly. Between 1901 and 1910, tin production rose from about 50 tons to nearly 600 tons as the licensed area on the plateau expanded and the railway arrived to carry the ore, according to a history of Nigerian tin mining published by the development organisation R4D.

The same story repeated in the south. Coal was found at Enugu in 1909, and Britannica records coal mining in the Enugu area beginning in 1915, with the railway as a principal customer. Columbite, which occurs alongside tin, was extracted in growing amounts from the 1940s and, according to R4D, peaked in the 1950s.

By the middle of the twentieth century, Nigeria was a major producer of tin, columbite and coal. Mining was not a footnote. It was an industry tied to the railway in both directions: the line carried the ore out, and the coal fuelled the engines.

## The turn to oil

Then came 1956. Oil was found in the Niger Delta, and the country's attention moved. A 1957 review of colonial geological surveys shows the shift happening in real time: the Nigerian geological department was by then working closely with Shell-BP, which held oil exploration licences in the south, while Mobil began prospecting in the north in 1956.

The consequences for minerals came in stages. Britannica notes that coal declined after the late 1950s with the discovery of oil. It also notes that columbite production has declined since the mid-1970s and that tin-smelting capacity went unused after world demand dropped in the late 1980s. Stephen Mallo of the University of Jos, writing on the Nigerian mining sector, lists several forces working together: rising world demand for petroleum, the collapse of international markets for mineral commodities, and the indigenisation decree of the early 1970s, which complicated the sector's ability to keep developing.

It was not a dramatic collapse. It was a drift. Money, talent and political attention flowed to where the money was easiest, and the mines were left to the people who had no alternative.

## What the numbers say

The Nigeria Extractive Industries Transparency Initiative, NEITI, has tracked the result. According to its data as reported by BusinessDay, the mining sector's contribution to GDP declined from 5.6% in 1980 to about 0.33% in 2020.

Pause on that for a moment. In 1980, mining was more than five percent of the Nigerian economy. By 2020, you could hardly find it on the chart.

I should be careful about what I am claiming, because the temptation in a book like this is to say that mining "funded Nigeria". Oil did that. For the last half century, crude oil has paid the bills, and nothing in these pages disputes it. The accurate claim is different and, I think, more interesting: **Nigeria had a functioning mining economy, one that made it a significant producer on the world stage, and over a few decades it allowed that economy to shrink to almost nothing while an entire generation grew up believing it never existed.**

## The bill that came due

The history has a darker side, and a trustworthy guide must mention it. The old mining model left scars. R4D reports that communities around the Jos Plateau are still dealing with abandoned mines and the health hazards they leave behind, including pools left by tin extraction. Colonial companies pulled out, the state did not take up the burden, and the land and its people paid.

This matters for readers of this book for two reasons. First, it is a reminder that mining done carelessly can destroy more than it creates, which is why Chapter 11 spends so much time on rules, safety and responsible sourcing. Second, it explains why many Nigerians feel ambivalent about mining. They are not wrong to be wary of an industry that has sometimes taken from communities and left them with the bill.

The lesson is not to avoid mining. It is to do it differently.

## Why the history matters to Amaka

For Amaka, sitting with her calculator, this is not nostalgia. It is evidence. It shows that Nigeria has done this before. It shows that the minerals, the skills and the markets are not hypothetical. And it shows that the near-disappearance of an industry is not the same as the absence of an opportunity. It is, if anything, a sign of room.

The next chapter looks at what is happening to that room today.

CHAPTER 2

# Beyond Black Gold

*Gold, gemstones and the other treasure under our feet*

Oil is not the villain of this story. It has paid for roads, salaries and a great deal of national life. The problem is not that we dug it. The problem is that we stopped looking at anything else.

This chapter widens the view. It asks what else Nigeria has, how much of it we can honestly measure, and why the conversation about it is changing now.

## More than one kind of wealth

The head of the Solid Minerals Development Fund has said that Nigeria has more than 44 commercially viable minerals across over 500 locations. Those include the ones in this book, gold and gemstones, but also iron ore, limestone, coal, bitumen, lithium and many more. This book concentrates on gold, gemstones and jewellery for a practical reason. They are the part of the mineral economy where an ordinary person is most likely to find an entry point, because their value chain runs from the mine all the way to a shop counter, a wedding and a gift box.

Oil is a vast, capital-intensive business. For most Nigerians the realistic ways to take part are to work for someone else or to buy what is sold. Gold, gemstones and jewellery work differently. They have a mine at one end, but they also have makers, traders, designers and sellers who

operate at every scale from a market stall to a factory. That is a difference in structure, not in importance, and it is the reason this industry belongs in a conversation about everyday livelihoods.

## What we know, and what we do not

This is the place where many books on Nigerian mining lose their credibility, because they quote large numbers without saying where the numbers come from. Let me do the opposite and show you where the evidence is firm and where it is thin.

| What you may hear | What the evidence supports |
|---|---|
| **"Mining is a big share of the economy."** | The Minister of Solid Minerals Development has said the sector contributed less than 1% of GDP for decades. The head of the Solid Minerals Development Fund has said solid minerals exports were about ₦354 billion in 2025, roughly 0.4% of total exports. |
| **"Mining grew 4.61%, so it is now 4.61% of GDP."** | No. The National Bureau of Statistics reported that mining and quarrying, a broad category that includes crude oil and natural gas, *grew* by 4.61% in the second quarter of 2025. That is a growth rate. |
| **"Millions of Nigerians work in mining."** | Nobody knows. Africa Check examined a 2018 ministerial claim of two million people depending on artisanal and small-scale mining and rated it unproven. The planetGOLD programme, citing Nigeria's national action plan for artisanal gold mining, reports about 260,000 miners relying directly on it and 1.3 million more indirectly. |
| **"Most mining is informal."** | This one has broad support. planetGOLD says roughly 75% of artisanal activity operates outside current laws, and NEITI's executive secretary has said more than 80% of the sector, particularly artisanal mining, is unregulated. |
| **"Billions of dollars of gemstones leave Nigeria every year."** | Unofficial exports are, by nature, unrecorded. Estimates circulate, but none is reliable enough to quote, so this book does not quote one. |

There is a reason to dwell on this. When the foundation of a story is exaggerated, the person who builds on it gets hurt. The honest picture is less thrilling than the advertising, and it is still compelling: a **small,**

**informal, under-measured sector with large potential and rising official attention.**

## The change in attention

The attention is real. It shows up in several places.

**Gold has a buyer at the top.** In 2019 the Federal Government launched the Presidential Artisanal Gold Mining Development Initiative, known as PAGMI, to bring artisanal gold into the formal economy. At its centre is the National Gold Purchase Programme, under which the Central Bank of Nigeria buys locally produced gold in naira to add to its reserves. The gold must be refined to the London Bullion Market Association's Good Delivery standard and responsibly sourced under the OECD Due Diligence Guidance. For an artisanal miner, that is the beginning of a guaranteed market.

**Money has been promised.** President Tinubu announced a ₦4.5 trillion increase in the 2025 budget, with ₦1 trillion earmarked for the solid minerals sector. Whether and how it is spent is something to watch, not to assume.

**Official revenue is rising from a low base.** The Minister has said government revenue from the sector rose from ₦16 billion in 2023 to ₦38 billion in 2024 and was expected to exceed ₦70 billion in 2025. The Solid Minerals Development Fund has said the sector recorded real growth of 33.5% in 2025, against 3.9% for the economy as a whole. These are official statements, and they describe growth from a very small starting point, which is how very fast percentages are produced.

**Value addition is policy.** The Ministry has been training Nigerians to cut, polish and set gemstones, because the Minister has said that most Nigerian gemstones are exported without value addition. Training programmes under the World Bank-assisted MinDiver project have produced graduates in gemstone and jewellery making, and the Ministry has announced plans for jewellery training centres.

## The gap is the opportunity

Put these together and a pattern emerges. A sector that was once a significant producer has shrunk to a small share of the economy. A government is now saying it wants to rebuild it, and has created a buyer for gold, a training pipeline for gemstone skills, and a policy push for local processing. Meanwhile, much of the value in the chain is still captured outside Nigeria, or by informal middlemen, or not captured at all.

When value is leaking, there is room to catch it. That is not a promise of profit. It is a reason to look closely.

## Not oil or minerals

One last point, because it matters. I am not asking Nigeria to abandon oil, and I am not claiming that gold and gemstones will replace it. The argument is about concentration. An economy that depends on one resource is exposed when that resource disappoints, and so are the households that depend on that economy. Amaka cannot change oil policy. She can change what she knows, and where she looks for her next customer.

To look properly, she first needs to understand how the industry is put together. That is the subject of the next chapter.

CHAPTER 3

# The Chain

*How a rock becomes a ring, and where you can stand along the way*

Take any gold ring on any finger at any Nigerian wedding. It looks like a single object, but it is the end of a long relay. Somebody found the gold. Somebody dug it. Somebody bought it, melted it, refined it, cast it, soldered it, polished it and sold it. Somebody photographed it for a catalogue. Somebody delivered it. Somebody collected the money and recorded it in a book.

Economists call this relay a value chain. For anyone thinking about entering the industry, it is the most useful idea in this book, because it dissolves the biggest misunderstanding about mining: that to take part, you must own the mine.

## Six links

**Exploration → Mining → Processing → Manufacturing → Distribution → Retail**

| Link | What happens | Who earns here | How accessible is it? |
|---|---|---|---|
| **1. Exploration** | Geologists map and test ground to find deposits worth mining | Geologists, surveyors, drilling and laboratory firms, data providers | Specialist; needs a licence, capital and expertise |

| Link | What happens | Who earns here | How accessible is it? |
|---|---|---|---|
| **2. Mining** | Ore, gold or rough stones are extracted | Licensed mining companies, small-scale lease holders, artisanal miners | Regulated; needs a mineral title (Chapter 11) |
| **3. Processing** | Gold is aggregated and refined; rough stones are sorted, then cut and polished | Buying centres, refiners, lapidaries, assayers and testing laboratories | Mixed; skilled trades are learnable, refining is capital-heavy |
| **4. Manufacturing** | Metal and stones become finished jewellery and accessories | Goldsmiths, jewellery makers, designers, beaders | Open to skilled people with modest equipment |
| **5. Distribution** | Products move from makers to sellers | Wholesalers, agents, logistics firms | Open to anyone with suppliers, trust and transport |
| **6. Retail** | Customers buy | Shops, market traders, online sellers, event vendors | The most accessible; also the most crowded |

Read the right-hand column slowly. The links on the left are capital-heavy, technical and regulated. The links on the right are skills-heavy, relationship-heavy and, in many cases, open to a person with a small budget and a good idea. The industry's wealth is created at the left, but a good deal of its employment and entrepreneurship happens toward the right.

## Two chains, not one

Gold and gemstones travel along different routes, and it helps to see both.

**The gold chain.** Much of Nigeria's gold is dug by artisanal and small-scale miners. The government's plan under PAGMI is to source, aggregate, process and refine this gold through registered buying centres and aggregators, and to supply refined bars to the Central Bank of Nigeria. That makes the chain, on paper, a clean ladder: miner, buying

centre, refinery, central bank. Alongside it runs a private market that supplies jewellers, which is where the downstream opportunities lie. Refining capacity is a work in progress. The Ministry approved the first gold refinery licence to Kian Smith Nigeria Limited in 2018, and the company said its output would go both to the Central Bank and to the jewellery industry.

**The gemstone chain.** Gemstones are mostly dug by artisanal miners, then traded onward, frequently as rough stones. The step that adds the most value, cutting and polishing, is where Nigeria has been building skills. The Nigerian Institute of Mining and Geosciences in Jos runs short courses in precious stone identification, gem cutting and polishing, and the World Bank-assisted MinDiver project has funded master training in gemstone and jewellery making and design. The Minister has said the problem is plain: most Nigerian gemstones leave the country without any value being added to them.

## The mistake most newcomers make

Most people who get excited about this industry make the same mistake. They ask: how do I get into mining? It is the wrong question, and it is dangerous. It sends them toward the most regulated, most capital-intensive and most fraud-prone link in the chain, often before they understand anything else.

The better question is: **which link fits my skills, my money and my appetite for risk?**

A few examples will show how different the answers can be.

- A jewellery brand can buy finished stones and metal from verified suppliers, never touch a mine, and still build something valuable through design, quality and service.
- A photographer can serve a dozen jewellers without owning a single gemstone.
- A trader can specialise in moving finished pieces from a maker in one city to buyers in another.

- An accountant can help small jewellers meet their registration and tax obligations, a service that grows more valuable as the rules tighten.
- A trained lapidary can cut stones for makers who have no cutting skill.

None of these people owns a mine. All of them earn from the industry.

## Amaka at the map

Here is where Amaka's journey changes. Until now she has thought of the industry as a place with a door she could not afford to open. Looking at the chain, she sees that there are many doors. She sews, and she has a good eye for colour. She has friends who buy jewellery for weddings and complain that nothing looks distinctive. Somewhere between manufacturing and retail, between design and distribution, there may be a place for her.

Whether there truly is will depend on what she learns. The next four chapters walk through the main opportunities one at a time: gold, gemstones, jewellery and beads, and the services that surround them all.

> **Key message:** You can earn at any link of the chain without owning the whole chain.

PART II

# The Opportunities

CHAPTER 4

# The Gold Opportunity

*The oldest store of value, and the newest national project*

Human beings have valued gold for thousands of years for the plainest of reasons. It does not rust. It is beautiful. It is scarce. And it is accepted nearly everywhere. Nigerians know this without being taught: gold is what a family gives at a wedding, what a mother keeps in a box, what a businessman buys when he does not trust the year ahead.

In Nigeria, gold has also become a matter of national policy. When the Central Bank of Nigeria bought its first locally sourced gold bar in July 2020, BusinessDay reported that the 12.5 kilogram bar cost ₦268 million. It was a small purchase by the standards of central banks, but a large signal: Nigeria's own gold could now enter the country's reserves.

That shift has changed the shape of the gold economy. Let us walk through it.

## Where gold comes from

The Federal Government's PAGMI programme identified Kebbi, Zamfara, Kaduna, Niger and Osun as the main gold-producing belt, with Kebbi and Osun as pilot states. About 20,000 miners in those two states had by then been registered biometrically. Most of Nigeria's gold comes from

artisanal and small-scale miners who dig by hand, with simple equipment, often outside the formal system. That is the starting point, and it explains both the opportunity and the risk.

## Six ways to take part

**1. Exploration and licensed mining.** Finding and extracting gold requires a mineral title from the Mining Cadastre Office. The office lists six titles: the Reconnaissance Permit, Exploration Licence, Small Scale Mining Lease, Quarry Lease, Mining Lease and Water Use Permit (Mining Cadastre Office). For gold, the relevant ones are normally the Exploration Licence, and then a Small Scale Mining Lease or a Mining Lease. Chapter 11 explains the differences. This is the path that needs the most capital, expertise and patience, and it is the one most often misdescribed to newcomers.

**2. Buying, aggregating and trading.** A person or company does not need a mining title to buy and trade gold, but does need the right permit. A law-firm summary of the Mining Act describes a Possess and Purchase Licence, which lets the holder buy and trade the minerals named in it anywhere in the country, and a Mineral Buying Centre Licence, which allows buying, storing and trading at a licensed location. It describes both as 12-month licences, renewed yearly. Check the current terms and fees with the Mining Cadastre Office. Dealers in precious metals and stones must also register with the Special Control Unit against Money Laundering, now part of the Economic and Financial Crimes Commission (SCUML).

**3. Refining and processing.** Refining turns semi-pure gold into high-purity bars, and it is licensed and capital-intensive. For most readers, the realistic relationship with refining is as a supplier, service provider or customer, not an owner.

**4. Jewellery production.** Goldsmiths turn metal into finished pieces. It is a skills business: casting, soldering, stone-setting, finishing, repair and design. Chapter 6 covers it in depth.

**5. Retail and distribution.** Selling gold jewellery from a shop, a market stall or an online store is the most accessible way in, provided you buy from verified suppliers and keep proper records.

**6. Equipment and professional services.** Mining and jewellery businesses need tools, safety equipment, testing devices, packaging, transport, accounting and marketing. Chapter 7 covers these.

## A short education in karats

Before you buy or sell any gold, learn this. Karat measures purity out of 24 parts. Twenty-four karat is pure gold. Eighteen karat is 18 parts gold in 24, or 75%. Fourteen karat is about 58%. The rest is other metals added for strength or colour. A seller who cannot tell you the karat of a piece, and show how it was tested, is a seller to walk away from.

## Meet a goldsmith (who does not exist)

Let me introduce another composite, a goldsmith I will call Tunde. He is an invention, but his situation is common. He trained as an apprentice, he is good with his hands, and he makes beautiful chains and rings. His trouble is not skill. It is that he sells only to people who walk into his small workshop.

Tunde does not need a mine. He needs three things: a reliable source of gold he can trust, a way to show customers his work beyond the shop door, and the paperwork that makes bigger buyers comfortable doing business with him. The first is a supplier question. The second is a photography and marketing question. The third is a registration and compliance question. Notice that two of those three are services someone else could provide, which is the subject of Chapter 7.

## The risks, plainly

- **Authenticity.** Plated, filled and fake pieces circulate. Buy from suppliers who can show testing or assay evidence, and test what you resell.

- **Price movement.** Gold prices move with world markets and the naira exchange rate. Stock bought at one price can sell for less later. This book quotes no gold prices because they change daily.
- **Illegal sourcing.** The Federal Government has linked illegal artisanal mining to mercury and lead poisoning and to insecurity in some mining areas, and cites more than 7,000 lead-poisoning incidents and 700 deaths in Zamfara and Kebbi between 2010 and 2016. Buying from unregistered sources can expose you to legal and reputational harm.
- **Cash and fraud.** Gold deals involving large cash payments, advance fees or pressure to move fast are the classic scam pattern. Chapter 11 lists the warning signs.

> **Opportunity Spotlight: a jewellery retail business built on verified suppliers.** You do not mine or refine. You choose finished pieces from suppliers who can prove what they sell, add your own brand, service and care, and earn the margin between what you pay and what you charge.
> **What You Need to Start:** a registered business, a trusted supplier relationship, secure storage, a way to test or verify items, and SCUML registration if you deal in jewellery or precious metals as a business.
> **Potential Customers:** individuals buying for weddings, anniversaries and gifts; corporate gift buyers; and traders buying for resale.
> **Risks to Understand:** fake or mislabelled stock, price swings on inventory, theft, and cash tied up in pieces that do not sell.
> **Your First Step:** visit three established jewellers as a customer. Ask how they test items, what documents they keep, and who supplies them. Write down what you learn.

CHAPTER 5

# The Gemstone Opportunity

*The stones that leave Nigeria as rock and return as jewellery*

Gold is the story that governments tell. Gemstones are the story that the ground tells, if you know how to read it.

Under the hills of the Jos Plateau, in the pegmatite belts of Oyo and Kwara, in the highlands of Taraba, there are stones that become something extraordinary once a skilled person has cut and polished them: tourmaline in pinks, reds and blues, sapphire, topaz, garnet, amethyst. A rough stone is an unremarkable thing, a dull lump that might be mistaken for gravel. A polished gem, in the right hands, is an object people will pay a great deal to own.

The distance between those two states is what this chapter is about.

## What Nigeria produces

The US Geological Survey, which has tracked Nigeria's mineral output for years, records artisanal production of several gem materials. It reports that Plateau State accounts for much of Nigeria's reported gemstone production, mined on the Jos Plateau by artisanal miners. The most recent detailed figures I could find run through 2018:

| Gem material | Where the USGS recorded production | Figures reported (USGS) |
|---|---|---|
| **Topaz** | Plateau State; new mines in Niger State | 22,240 kg nationwide in 2018, of which Niger State produced 15,000 kg |

| Gem material | Where the USGS recorded production | Figures reported (USGS) |
|---|---|---|
| **Garnet** | Plateau State | 800 kg in 2018 |
| **Amethyst** | Plateau State | About 6,300 kg in 2018 |
| **Rubellite tourmaline** | Oyo State, from pegmatite deposits | About 5,500 kg in 2017; between 3,500 and 5,300 miners involved |
| **Indicolite tourmaline** | Kwara State | Mined; no tonnage given |
| **Sapphire** | Taraba State | An estimated 320 kg in 2017 and 640 kg in 2018 |

Two cautions. First, these are 2017 and 2018 figures, and mining locations and volumes change, so treat them as evidence of where activity has been documented, not as a current map. Second, they are quantities of rough material, not values, and the value of a gem depends far more on quality than weight.

There is one more detail worth dwelling on. The USGS reported that most of Oyo State's tourmaline was exported to Thailand. Thailand has a long tradition of gemstone cutting. That is the whole story in a sentence: Nigerian ground, Nigerian miners, foreign lapidaries, foreign value.

## The step that adds the most

The Minister of Solid Minerals Development has said that a gemstone's value increases when it is cut and polished, and that most Nigerian gemstones had been exported without that step because the know-how and machinery were lacking. The government's response has been training. The World Bank-assisted MinDiver project has funded master training in gemstone and jewellery making and design, and the Nigerian Institute of Mining and Geosciences in Jos runs short courses in precious stone identification, gem cutting and polishing. In 2024 the Minister also announced plans for jewellery training centres across the country.

A lapidary, the person who cuts and polishes stones, does something close to magic and close to engineering. The stone is studied for colour, flaws and the direction of its crystal. A plan is made. Facets are ground one at a time on a spinning lap until the stone returns light the way its nature allows. It takes training, a steady hand and patience. It also takes machines, which is why the capital is modest compared with mining, but not zero.

## How to judge a stone

The trade judges coloured stones on four things: **colour, clarity, cut and carat weight.** Beyond those, a serious buyer wants to know whether the stone is natural or synthetic, and whether it has been treated, for example by heat or dye, because treatment affects value and must be disclosed. Ask for treatments in writing.

The old labels "precious" (ruby, sapphire, emerald, diamond) and "semi-precious" (nearly everything else) sound authoritative, but do not let them decide value for you. A fine, well-cut tourmaline can be worth more than a poor sapphire. Quality sets price, not category.

## The rules that apply to traders

Buying and selling minerals as a business needs the correct permits (Chapter 11). Exporting minerals commercially needs a Mineral Export Permit, which the law-firm summary describes as valid for each shipment. Dealers in precious stones are also designated businesses that must register with SCUML. The gem trade is old, global and full of people who know more than you do. The way to protect yourself is to learn first, buy small, and keep records.

## Selling confidence

In the gemstone trade you are never really selling a stone. You are selling confidence that it is what you say it is. For smaller pieces, honest labelling is the minimum: name the stone, say whether it is natural or

treated, and say where it came from if you know. For stones of real value, buyers will ask for an independent gemmological report, and a seller who welcomes the request is usually one worth dealing with.

**Opportunity Spotlight: from rough stone to marketable gem.** A rough stone is bought from a legitimate source, sorted for quality, planned and cut by a trained lapidary, polished, identified, documented and then sold loose or set in jewellery. Every step is a separate skill and a separate business, and each increases value when done well.
**What You Need to Start:** gemstone identification knowledge (take a course before you buy any stock), a legitimate supplier, a small budget for your first stones, good light and simple testing tools, and the correct permits if you trade minerals as a business.
**Potential Customers:** jewellers and designers, collectors, tourists and diaspora buyers, and individuals buying engagement and anniversary gifts.
**Risks to Understand:** synthetic or treated stones sold as natural, stones of unknown origin, theft, and buying more than you can sell.
**Your First Step:** enrol in a short gemstone identification course. Then buy a few inexpensive stones from a verified seller and practise describing them in writing.

CHAPTER 6

# The Jewellery and Beading Economy

*Where craft meets commerce, and where most people will start*

If the mine feels far away, jewellery is where the industry meets daily life. It is on the neck of the bride, the wrist of the mother, the hand of the chief. It is given, worn, inherited and displayed. And it is the part of this industry where skill and taste can count for more than capital, which makes it the most realistic starting point for a large number of readers.

## Beads are part of who we are

Before a gold chain or a polished gem, many Nigerians first met jewellery in the form of beads. Among the Yoruba, coral beads are treasured as ornaments and as spiritual talismans, and they are worn at weddings, naming ceremonies and traditional rites of passage. Among the Edo, coral beads are symbols of power, prestige, wealth, royalty and beauty, worn mostly at traditional weddings and cultural events. Among the Esan people of Edo State, beads serve as markers of social rank, as personal adornment, as spiritual symbols and as part of cultural rites.

That cultural weight is also economic weight. Every wedding season, every installation of a chief, every naming ceremony and every cultural festival creates demand for beadwork, ceremonial sets and accessories.

This is a market that does not need to be invented. It has existed for generations, and it renews itself every time a family celebrates.

A word on honesty before we go further. Not every red bead is natural coral. Beads are made from natural coral, glass, stone and other materials, and imitation coral is common. Whatever you sell, say plainly what it is made of. In cultural markets, where buyers know what they want and talk to each other, a reputation for honesty is worth more than any single sale.

## Eight ways to earn

The jewellery and beading economy is not one business but many. Here are eight, in roughly increasing order of capital required.

1. **Repairs, resizing and redesign.** Customers own jewellery they no longer wear. Restringing, resizing and remodelling is steady, repeat business that needs skill more than stock.
2. **Custom jewellery.** Make-to-order pieces for engagements, anniversaries and milestones. Customers commit before you buy materials, which lowers your stock risk.
3. **Traditional and contemporary beadwork.** Combine heritage styles with modern accessories such as earrings, bracelets and statement pieces.
4. **Ceremonial and bridal sets.** Complete sets for traditional weddings, where customers want pieces that coordinate with their outfits.
5. **Online jewellery stores.** Sell through Instagram, WhatsApp, marketplaces or your own website, backed by strong photography and clear descriptions.
6. **Packaging and branding.** Good boxes, pouches, care cards and logos lift perceived value and can be a business in their own right.
7. **Distribution.** Supply other sellers with beads, findings, chains and finished pieces.

8. **Design-led brands.** Build a recognisable style, commission skilled makers, and own the relationship with the customer.

## Training you can use

You do not have to learn alone. The Federal Government, with the World Bank-assisted MinDiver project, has run master training in gemstone and jewellery making and design, with graduates receiving starter packs. One graduate of the October 2022 batch said she had long worked in cutting, polishing, testing and grading precious stones but had never incorporated the stones into jewellery until the programme. The Minister has since announced plans for jewellery training centres across the country, and the Nigerian Institute of Mining and Geosciences in Jos runs short courses. Ask what is open now.

## Nigerian design on a world stage

In 2025, Women in Mining in Nigeria backed Miss Universe Nigeria 2025, whose crown was designed entirely by Nigerian women. WIMIN described the collaboration as a way of showing Nigerian craftsmanship to the world and of attracting investors and creating work for young designers and artisans. A crown is a symbolic object, but it points at something practical: Nigerian designers can be seen, and when they are seen, they can be paid.

## Building a brand without a factory

Many successful jewellery brands own no factory. They own a point of view: a style, a story, a customer they understand deeply. They work with skilled goldsmiths, beaders and lapidaries, control quality, and put their own energy into design, photography, packaging and customer care.

## Amaka's idea

Back to Amaka. She sews. She has a good eye for colour. She also knows, because her friends complain about it, that bridal sets in her city tend to look alike. Her idea, which she has not yet tested, is a small line of coordinated accessories for traditional weddings, designed to match the fabrics families choose for their celebration, made by two beaders she already knows, photographed carefully and sold through WhatsApp and Instagram.

Is this idea good? Neither of us knows yet. What we do know is how she should find out. She should design three sets, show photographs to ten brides-to-be, and ask them plainly what they would pay. She should make only what they say they will buy. That test costs her very little, and it can save her a great deal.

> **Opportunity Spotlight: a jewellery brand without a factory.** You design a small collection, commission a skilled maker to produce it in small batches, photograph it well, sell it to a defined customer such as brides, professionals or corporate gift buyers, and reinvest early profits in the pieces that sell fastest.
> **What You Need to Start:** a clear customer and style, a reliable maker or your own skill, a small materials budget, good photography, a way to take payment, and a business registration. Register with SCUML if you deal in jewellery as a business.
> **Potential Customers:** brides and grooms, families preparing for ceremonies, traditional title holders, event stylists, gift buyers, tourists and diaspora customers.
> **Risks to Understand:** copied designs, unreliable makers, quality inconsistency, slow-moving stock and mislabelled materials.
> **Your First Step:** design three pieces for one specific customer. Show photographs to ten people in that group and ask what they would pay. Make only what they say they will buy.

CHAPTER 7

# The Opportunities Nobody Talks About

*Making money by serving the industry*

In every gold rush in history, the stories that last are not always about the miners. They are often about the people who sold the miners what they needed: the tools, the food, the lodging, the credit, the maps. Many of those people did better than the diggers, with less risk.

Today's version needs no shovels. It needs skills.

The gold, gemstone and jewellery economy is full of small businesses that are very good at one thing, such as casting a ring, cutting a stone or beading a bridal set, and very bad at everything else. They do not have a website. Their product photographs are dark. Their books are in a notebook. They do not know whether they are meant to be registered with anyone. They lose sales and sleep over problems that someone with a different skill could solve in an afternoon.

That someone could be you.

## How big is this market?

I would like to give you a headcount of the people in the industry who might need your services, but it does not exist. Africa Check examined a 2018 ministerial claim that two million Nigerians depended on artisanal

and small-scale mining and rated it unproven. The planetGOLD programme, citing Nigeria's national action plan, estimates about 260,000 miners rely directly on artisanal gold mining, with 1.3 million more involved indirectly. And those figures cover miners only, not the jewellers, beaders, traders and designers downstream, who are harder still to count.

So the honest statement is this: nobody can say exactly how many customers are out there. What is clear is that the sector is large enough to be worth official attention, mostly informal, and chronically underserved by professional services. If you are the one person in a trade association who understands product photography, you do not need a million customers. You need ten.

## Nine service opportunities

| Service | What a mining, gemstone or jewellery business needs | Skills you may already have |
|---|---|---|
| **Digital marketing and social media** | Regular posts, ads, WhatsApp catalogues, campaign planning | Content writing, design, ad management |
| **Photography and product videography** | Clear, attractive images of small, reflective products | Macro photography, lighting, editing |
| **Website and e-commerce development** | Online stores, catalogues, payment and delivery set-up | Web development, Shopify or WooCommerce, UX |
| **Logistics and transportation** | Secure, insured movement of valuable items | Courier operations, route planning, security awareness |
| **Equipment maintenance** | Repair of polishing machines, torches, saws, scales | Mechanical or electrical repair |
| **Packaging and branding** | Boxes, pouches, labels, logos, care cards | Graphic design, printing, tailoring, leatherwork |

| Service | What a mining, gemstone or jewellery business needs | Skills you may already have |
|---|---|---|
| **Accounting, legal and compliance** | Bookkeeping, tax filing, contracts, regulatory registration | Accounting, law, company secretarial work |
| **Training and education** | Courses on stone identification, design, business skills | Teaching, curriculum design, workshop facilitation |
| **Software and technology** | Inventory tracking, customer records, traceability tools | Software development, data management |

## Why compliance is its own opportunity

The rules in this industry are getting more demanding, which is bad news for the unprepared and good news for anyone who can help them. Mining companies and dealers in precious metals and stones are designated businesses that must register with SCUML and maintain anti-money-laundering programmes (DLA Piper). Tax law changed on 1 January 2026, with the commencement of the Nigeria Tax Act 2025 (Guardian). Many small jewellers do not have the time or knowledge to navigate this alone.

An accountant, lawyer or consultant who understands both the rules and the trade can offer a package: registration support, record-keeping systems, staff training and periodic reviews. It is a service that sells itself the moment a customer is asked for a document they do not have.

## Tunde's problem, solved by other people

Remember Tunde, the composite goldsmith from Chapter 4. His three problems were a trustworthy gold supplier, a way to show his work beyond his shop, and the paperwork that bigger buyers want. The second is a job for a photographer and a social media manager. The third

is a job for a bookkeeper and a compliance adviser. Tunde would happily pay all of them, if someone offered him a clear service at a fair price and spoke his language.

## How to win your first client

1. **Pick one service and one type of customer.** "Product photography for jewellery designers in Lagos" is stronger than "creative services".
2. **Create a small sample of work.** Offer to photograph, write or design for two or three businesses at a reduced rate in exchange for an honest testimonial.
3. **Learn the language.** Know the difference between a rough and a polished stone, between plated and solid gold, and between a bead and a gemstone. Clients trust people who understand their trade.
4. **Show up where they gather.** Industry events put owners, designers and suppliers in one room. Chapter 13 explains how to use them.
5. **Price for value, not for time.** A photographer whose images help a jeweller sell more is worth more than the hours behind the camera.

**Key message:** You can take part in this industry by solving problems that existing businesses already have.
**Opportunity Spotlight: a specialist service for jewellery sellers.** One person offers a monthly package for small jewellers: ten product photographs, four short videos, a caption bank and a content calendar, at a fixed fee agreed with each client.
**What You Need to Start:** a skill you can already deliver, a portfolio of a few samples, a simple service menu with prices, and a way to receive payment.
**Potential Customers:** independent jewellers, bead sellers, gemstone traders, designers, training schools, event organisers and small mining-service companies.
**Risks to Understand:** late payment, clients who change requirements, and dependence on one or two customers.
**Your First Step:** list ten businesses in the industry whose online presence could be stronger. For each, write down one specific improvement you could offer.

PART III

# The Women

CHAPTER 8

# Women in Mining: The Hands That Were Always There

*The people who have worked this industry longest, and are least often counted*

If you want to understand who actually keeps the gold and gemstone economy running, do not start with the boardrooms. Start with the market, the washing site, the workshop and the bead table. Look at who is there.

Very often, it is women.

This chapter is about them: what they do, what they face, what the numbers say, and what an organisation of Nigerian women built in the face of a male-dominated industry. It is placed in the middle of this book because it belongs in the middle. Any reader who wants to enter this industry, whether a man or a woman, will meet women's work at every link of the chain, and will do better by understanding it.

## A picture the numbers cannot quite draw

Let me introduce another composite. I will call her Hauwa. She is not a real person, but women like her exist in mining communities across the country. She works at a site where gold-bearing material is dug, carried and washed. She does a great deal of the physical work. She is not on

any payroll. Nobody has recorded her name, her hours or her earnings, and when the site is described in a report, it is described as a place where men mine.

Hauwa is the reason the statistics in this chapter must be read with care. They are real, but they undercount.

## What the data say, and where they disagree

| Measure | What is reported |
|---|---|
| **Women in the global artisanal and small-scale mining workforce** | About one-third, according to the World Bank (2024) |
| **Women in the African artisanal and small-scale workforce** | The African Union's African Minerals Development Centre says no less than 40 to 50% |
| **Women in Nigeria's solid minerals workforce** | NEITI's 2019 report put the share at 6.8% |
| **Where women work** | A study by the African Centre for Leadership, Strategy and Development found women often involved in artisanal and small-scale mining at the upstream and midstream levels but excluded from the downstream |

The gap between the 6.8% and the 40 to 50% looks like a contradiction. It is more likely a difference in what is being counted. The Nigerian figure comes from audits of formal, reporting operations. The African figure describes the artisanal workforce, much of which operates informally and goes uncounted in official audits. This is my reading of the numbers, not a finding in any one source, so treat it as an interpretation. What the sources do agree on is that women's participation in Nigeria's recorded, formal mining is low, and their presence in the informal sector is substantial and poorly documented.

There is also a disagreement about the *downstream*. The study cited above says women are excluded from it. Women in Mining in Nigeria describes the opposite: the organisation's president has said women are

the major workers in the downstream segment, and that their creativity shows in the gems and gold sector, especially in jewellery design. The likely resolution is that "downstream" is being used for different things: processing and finance in one account, and design, making and selling in the other. In this book's terms, women are well represented in the design, making and selling end of the chain, and under-represented in ownership, licensing and formal employment at the mining end.

## The hard part

It would be dishonest to write about women in mining without writing about harm. The African Centre for Leadership, Strategy and Development recorded cases of gender-based violence in the extractive sector across six Nigerian mining communities. The president of Women in Mining in Nigeria has said that in many mining sites and host communities, women are abused, over-worked, underpaid and shortchanged, and that her organisation has launched programmes to safeguard women miners.

I mention this because a reader who wants to take part in the industry should know that it is not a neutral space, and because the practices that protect women, including written contracts, safe sites, fair pay and the formalisation of mining cooperatives, also protect everyone else. A responsible industry is a safer one.

## The organisation

Women in Mining in Nigeria, known as WIMIN, was founded in 2006 by Janet Adeyemi, a geologist and engineer who is also a former member of the National Assembly. In an interview with International Women in Mining, she said the idea grew out of an international conference where she met many women working in mining, and that the organisation began with 25 artisanal women miners in Jos. She has said elsewhere that she was moved to act when she found women being exploited at mining sites in Jos and excluded from the business of mining.

From that small start in Jos, the organisation has spread. News reports in 2025 describe WIMIN as operating in 28 states. Its work, as described by its president, covers capacity building, health and safety, responsible mining, inclusive governance and bringing women into the mineral market. She has said it trained over 1,000 women across five geopolitical zones in a single year on safe and sustainable mining practices, and set up the Women in Mining Training Institute, a monthly online class on mining operations, opportunities and the law.

WIMIN's argument for inclusion is not charity. At the launch of the 2025 conference, its president put it in a single line: any nation that sidelines nearly half of its population cannot grow.

## Where the opportunities are for women

For a woman reading this book, the picture is both sobering and encouraging. Sobering, because the barriers are real. Encouraging, because the places where women are strongest are the same places where Chapters 4 to 7 found the most accessible entry points.

- **Design and making.** Jewellery design, beadwork and finishing are fields where women's skill and cultural knowledge are already central. Nigerian women designers made the crown worn by Miss Universe Nigeria 2025, an effort backed by WIMIN.
- **Cooperatives.** Artisanal miners who organise into registered cooperatives gain a route to formal recognition. The Minister has said that over 250 cooperatives were formed within a year as part of the formalisation drive. Women who join or lead cooperatives are better placed to negotiate prices, access training and protect themselves.
- **Trading and retail.** Women are strong in selling, and the same skills apply to stones and jewellery. The legal requirements in Chapter 11 apply equally.
- **Services.** Photography, marketing, bookkeeping, logistics and training, covered in Chapter 7, are open to anyone with the skill.

- **Leadership and ownership.** The least crowded and most valuable position of all is as a title holder, licensed buyer or business owner. It requires capital and compliance, but there are programmes, networks and mentors for women who want it.

Men have a part here too. WIMIN's own description of its work speaks of supporting not only women labourers, professionals, operators and activists but also "he4she" allies. Fair contracts, safe sites and a real welcome for women are good for business as well as for justice.

## The conference built by women

The Gold & Gemstone Conference & Exhibition began as a WIMIN initiative. The organisation's own communique records the first Lagos edition as the first of its kind in the city. The 2026 edition, which Chapter 13 describes, carries a theme that puts women at its centre: *African Women Driving Africa's Gold and Gemstone Economy*. It will include dedicated conversations on women's participation and an Awards and Recognition segment honouring outstanding women and other industry figures.

If Hauwa is ever to be counted, she will be counted because people made the effort to count her. That work has started. It needs more hands, from women and men.

> **Key message:** Women are not a side topic in Nigerian mining. They are a central part of its workforce, its craft and its future, and the industry is better where they are included.
> **Your First Step:** find out whether there is a WIMIN chapter in your state. If you are a woman considering the industry, ask about training and mentoring. If you are a man, ask what allies can do.

PART IV

# Making It Real

CHAPTER 9

# Finding Your Entry Point

*Matching the opportunity to the person you actually are*

The worst way to enter this industry is to follow excitement. The best way is to match what you actually have (your skills, your money, your time, your contacts and your tolerance for risk) with a link in the chain that suits it.

In any industry, this goes wrong more often than it should. A person reads one inspiring story, jumps at the most glamorous option, and puts money into something they do not understand. The glamorous option in this industry is mining. It is also where the largest losses happen when homework is skipped.

So before you commit to anything, let us do the homework.

## Four doors

| Entry category | Examples | Primary requirement | Typical regulatory weight |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Skills and services** | Photography, marketing, branding, bookkeeping, web development | A marketable skill and a few clients | Light: ordinary business registration and tax |
| **Commerce** | Jewellery retail, accessories, bead selling, online stores | Suppliers, customers and working capital | Moderate: business registration, SCUML for jewellery and precious-metals dealers, tax |

| Entry category | Examples | Primary requirement | Typical regulatory weight |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Production** | Beading, goldsmithing, stone cutting and polishing, fabrication | Technical skill, training and equipment | Moderate: as above, plus workshop safety |
| **Mining and investment** | Licensed extraction, mineral trading, processing facilities | Capital, technical expertise and full compliance | Heavy: mineral titles or trading permits, environmental and community obligations |

Most readers should begin in the first three. The fourth is open to anyone who qualifies, but it is the door that has cost the most people the most money.

## Five questions, honestly answered

Take a notebook. Write your answers. There are no right ones. The point is to see yourself clearly.

**Skills.** What can you already do that someone would pay for? What could you learn within six months? Which practical or creative skill do you enjoy enough to practise for hundreds of hours?

**Resources.** How much money could you put in without harming your household if you lost all of it? How many hours a week can you give? What equipment, space or contacts do you already have?

**Interests.** Which of these energises you most: design and making, buying and selling, serving other businesses, technical and scientific work, or investing and deal-making?

**Experience.** Have you run a business or managed stock? Have you sold to customers, face to face or online? Have you worked in a regulated sector?

**Risk tolerance.** Could you survive a quarter with no sales? Would you rather earn small and steady amounts, or accept larger swings?

## Reading your answers

- **Strong skill, little money:** begin with services or production. You are selling talent and time, which cost nothing to stock.
- **Some savings and selling experience:** begin in commerce, with a small, tightly chosen range from verified suppliers.
- **Technical or scientific background:** look at production, such as lapidary, testing and assay, or at specialist services to miners.
- **Substantial capital and appetite for risk:** read Chapter 11 twice and seek independent legal, technical and financial advice before committing anything to mining or processing.

Whoever you are, avoid putting your entire savings into stock or a single deal in your first year.

## Amaka makes her list

Amaka took the questions seriously. Her skills: sewing, colour, an eye for what looks wrong. Her resources: a small amount of savings she could afford to lose, evenings, a phone with a decent camera, two beaders she trusts. Her interests: design and selling. Her experience: she has run a small clothing business. Her risk tolerance: modest.

She wrote down three opportunities to investigate, and I reproduce them as an illustration of how specific they can be.

1. **Coordinated bridal accessories** that match the fabric families choose for traditional weddings, made by two beaders and sold online. *Link in the chain: manufacturing and retail.*
2. **Repair and redesign** of old jewellery for customers who no longer wear what they own. *Link: manufacturing.*
3. **Social media and photography for two local jewellers**, as a service. *Link: a service to retail.*

Notice what she did not write down: *start a gold mine*. That is not because it is a bad idea. It is because it is not an idea for her, now.

## Your turn

By the end of this chapter, write down three realistic opportunities you want to investigate. For each one, answer:

1. Which link in the chain is it?
2. Who would pay me, and why?
3. What do I need to start, and how much do I already have?
4. Which rules apply to it?
5. What is the smallest test I could run in the next 30 days?

Keep this list. You will use it in Chapter 12.

CHAPTER 10

# The Million Naira Business Model

*Revenue is not profit, and sales are not wealth*

The title of this book needs an explanation, and this is the chapter where I owe you one.

"The Million Naira Opportunity" refers to the scale of the commercial opportunity across an industry. It does not mean that you will make a million naira. It certainly does not mean that you will make it quickly. And it is worth saying plainly that **₦1 million in sales is not ₦1 million in profit.** Understanding the difference is what separates a business that grows from one that looks busy and slowly runs out of money.

## A worked example

*This is an educational illustration with round numbers. It is not a price list for the market and it is not a forecast.*

Suppose a small jewellery business sells 100 items at ₦10,000 each in a month.

**Revenue = 100 × ₦10,000 = ₦1,000,000**

That sounds like a good month. Now count what it cost.

| Cost item (illustrative) | Amount (₦) |
|---|---|
| Cost of the 100 items (₦4,500 each) | 450,000 |
| Packaging | 40,000 |
| Delivery | 60,000 |
| Marketing | 100,000 |
| Other running costs (transport, data, repairs, payment charges) | 150,000 |
| **Total costs** | **800,000** |

**Profit before any applicable tax = ₦1,000,000 − ₦800,000 = ₦200,000**

The business made ₦1 million in sales and kept ₦200,000, a 20% net margin. And that ₦200,000 is not all the owner's to spend. Her own salary, rent or loan repayments, if any, have to come out of it or be counted as costs.

This is the arithmetic that disappoints people who confuse turnover with income. It is also the arithmetic that rewards people who learn it early.

## The vocabulary you need

- **Revenue** is the money customers pay you.
- **Cost of goods** is what you paid for the products you sold. Here, ₦450,000.
- **Gross profit** is revenue minus cost of goods: ₦1,000,000 − ₦450,000 = ₦550,000.
- **Gross margin** is gross profit as a share of revenue: ₦550,000 ÷ ₦1,000,000 = 55%.
- **Markup** is how much you add to cost. Here, ₦5,500 on a cost of ₦4,500, about 122%. Markup and margin are different numbers, and mixing them up is one of the commonest causes of mispricing.
- **Net profit** is what remains after all costs. Here, ₦200,000.

## Pricing

Start from your costs, but price for what the customer will pay and what the item is worth to them. A custom bridal set made to order is not priced like a mass-produced bracelet. Always include packaging, delivery, payment charges, your time, and a little for breakage or returns.

## Profit is not cash

Here is a trap that catches even experienced traders. Suppose you buy 100 items for ₦450,000 and only 40 sell in the first month. You have received ₦400,000 but spent ₦450,000 on stock alone, before packaging, marketing or delivery. You may be profitable on paper when all 100 sell, but you are short of cash today.

Jewellery and gemstone businesses are especially exposed to this, because stock is expensive and moves slowly. Buy in small batches. Track what sells. Reorder the winners.

## The cost of a customer

Calculate what it costs you to win one customer. In the example, ₦100,000 of marketing produced 100 sales, or ₦1,000 per sale. If marketing rose to ₦3,000 per sale, the same business would make much less. Referrals, repeat customers and honest reviews lower this cost over time, which is another reason honesty pays.

## Tax and registration

Nigeria's tax laws changed on 1 January 2026, when the Nigeria Tax Act 2025 and related laws took effect (Guardian explainer). The new framework includes relief for small companies, but published sources give different turnover thresholds and conditions, so confirm the current rules with the tax authority or a qualified accountant instead of relying on any figure in a book. Keep clean records from your first sale. It is the cheapest insurance you can buy.

## Scaling sustainably

1. Prove that a small version works before you enlarge it.
2. Grow stock only as fast as sales justify.
3. Keep personal money and business money separate.
4. Reinvest in what has been proven: the best-selling designs, the best marketing channel, the most reliable supplier.
5. Review your numbers every month.

## Your own numbers

Copy this table into a notebook or spreadsheet and complete it for each idea from Chapter 9. If you cannot fill in a row, that is information: it tells you what to find out before you spend money.

| Question | Your answer |
|---|---|
| What will I sell, and to whom? | |
| Price per unit (₦) | |
| Cost per unit, including materials (₦) | |
| Units I can realistically sell per month | |
| Monthly revenue (₦) | |
| Monthly packaging, delivery, marketing and running costs (₦) | |
| Monthly net profit (₦) | |
| Cash I must spend before my first sale (₦) | |
| How many months can I survive on low sales? | |

> **Key message:** Sustainable wealth creation depends on sound business economics, not impressive sales figures alone.

CHAPTER 11

# Entering the Industry Responsibly

*Licences, legitimacy and the mistakes that cost the most*

Here is a scenario, invented for illustration but built from the warning signs listed later in this chapter. Someone excited and well-meaning is offered a deal. The price is attractive. The seller is charming. There is a little pressure, because "other buyers are waiting". Money moves. The goods do not arrive, or they arrive and are not what was promised, or the paperwork turns out to describe something else entirely.

In any trade, many of the costliest mistakes come from skipping due diligence. This chapter is meant to spare you from learning that the hard way.

One warning first. **This chapter is not legal advice and it is not a complete licensing checklist.** Different activities need different approvals, and requirements change. Use it to understand how the rules are organised, then confirm the current position with the authorities named at the end.

## Step 1: Know which kind of activity you are in

| Activity | Typical examples | Main rules to check |
|---|---|---|
| **Mining and exploration** | Prospecting, digging, running a mine | Mineral title from the Mining Cadastre Office; environmental and community obligations |
| **Mineral buying and trading** | Buying gold or stones from miners and selling on | Mineral trading permits; SCUML registration |
| **Exporting minerals** | Shipping gold or stones abroad | Mineral Export Permit for each shipment |
| **Jewellery and gemstone retail or manufacturing** | Shops, makers, online sellers | Business registration; tax; SCUML registration for jewellery and precious-metals dealers |
| **Services to the industry** | Photography, marketing, accounting | Ordinary business registration and tax |

Mining is not the same as selling jewellery. A jewellery shop does not need a mineral title. A person who digs or buys raw minerals as a business needs the right permit.

## Step 2: Understand the mineral titles

The Nigerian Minerals and Mining Act 2007 established the Mining Cadastre Office (MCO), which the Act makes the agency responsible for administering mineral titles. The office lists six titles. A law-firm summary of the Act and the 2011 Regulations describes them as follows (DLA Piper):

| Title | What it allows | Duration as summarised |
|---|---|---|
| **Reconnaissance Permit** | Non-exclusive right to survey; small surface samples only | 1 year, renewable annually |
| **Exploration Licence** | Exploration in a defined area of up to 200 sq km | 3 years, renewable |

| Title | What it allows | Duration as summarised |
|---|---|---|
| **Small Scale Mining Lease** | Exclusive right to artisanal or low-technology mining in up to 3 sq km | 5 years, renewable |
| **Mining Lease** | Exclusive right to explore and exploit in the leased area | 25 years, renewable if obligations are met |
| **Quarry Lease** | Extraction of building materials such as granite, sand and gravel | Set by the MCO |
| **Water Use Permit** | Water use for mining operations | Lasts as long as the underlying licence |

The same summary describes separate trading instruments: a **Possess and Purchase Licence** and a **Mineral Buying Centre Licence**, each 12 months and renewable, and a **Mineral Export Permit** valid for each shipment. Titleholders also pay royalties, which the summary says range from 7.5% to 15% depending on the mineral. Fees, forms and timelines are published by the MCO and may have changed since this book was written.

## Step 3: Register your business and meet the filing rules

- **Register your business** with the Corporate Affairs Commission and obtain a Tax Identification Number.
- **Register with SCUML if you deal in jewellery, precious metals or precious stones.** The Special Control Unit against Money Laundering supervises dealers in these goods as Designated Non-Financial Businesses and Professions. Its registration guideline lists the documents required, including a certificate of incorporation for limited liability companies (SCUML).
- **File taxes on time** under the rules in force (see Chapter 10).

## Step 4: Source responsibly

Responsible sourcing means knowing where your gold or stones came from and ensuring that the trade did not fund harm. The Federal Government's gold purchase programme is designed around the OECD Due Diligence Guidance and the World Gold Council's London Principles. You may not operate at that scale, but the habits apply to everyone:

- Buy from suppliers who are registered and can name their own sources.
- Keep a written record of each purchase: date, supplier, description, weight or quantity, price and payment method.
- Prefer traceable payments to large cash payments.
- Avoid any supplier who cannot or will not explain where the material came from.

## Step 5: Verify suppliers and products

1. Ask for business registration documents and check them independently.
2. Visit the supplier's premises.
3. Start with a small order before a large one.
4. Have gold tested and stones identified by someone independent of the seller.
5. Put the terms in writing: what is being sold, the price, delivery, returns, and what happens if the goods are not as described.

## Step 6: Take safety and the environment seriously

Mining and processing carry real physical and environmental risks. The Federal Government cites more than 7,000 lead-poisoning incidents and 700 deaths linked to gold mining in Zamfara and Kebbi between 2010 and 2016, and links illegal artisanal mining to mercury poisoning (PAGMI). The planetGOLD programme estimates that artisanal gold

mining in Nigeria uses about 16.1 tonnes of mercury a year. If you invest in or work with miners, ask how they protect workers and the surrounding community.

## The warning signs of fraud

- Someone offers gold or stones "below market" and asks you to pay before you see and test the goods.
- You are told to pay an advance fee, "clearance" fee or "agent" fee to unlock a bigger deal.
- You are shown a photograph or a small sample, but the real goods are "in another country" or "with a third party".
- You are pressed to decide today, to keep it secret, or to avoid involving a lawyer.
- The seller cannot produce registration, a licence or traceable records.
- An investment promises fixed, guaranteed or unusually high returns from mining.
- Documents carry government logos or seals but cannot be verified with the issuing agency.

If any of these appear, stop. Verify with the relevant agency directly, using contact details you found yourself, not those the seller supplied.

## Where to confirm the current rules

| Question | Who to ask |
|---|---|
| **Mineral titles, fees and application procedures** | Mining Cadastre Office (miningcadastre.gov.ng) |
| **Policy, programmes and training for the sector** | Federal Ministry of Solid Minerals Development |
| **Geological data** | Nigerian Geological Survey Agency |

| Question | Who to ask |
|---|---|
| **Registration for jewellery and precious-metals dealers** | SCUML, Economic and Financial Crimes Commission |
| **Business registration** | Corporate Affairs Commission |
| **Tax obligations** | The Nigerian tax authorities, or a qualified accountant |
| **Gemstone identification and lapidary skills** | Nigerian Institute of Mining and Geosciences, Jos |

> **Key message:** The fastest way to lose money in this industry is to skip due diligence. The cheapest protection is a phone call to the right authority before you pay.

CHAPTER 12

# Your First 90 Days

*From reading to doing*

Knowledge only pays when it becomes action. This chapter turns the whole book into a plan you can start tomorrow.

It assumes you will keep your current income while you learn and test, and that you will risk only money you can afford to lose. It also assumes you are not trying to build an empire in three months. You are trying to answer a single question: *does this industry have a place for me?* Ninety days is enough to find out.

## Days 1 to 30: Research

**Goal:** choose one opportunity to test, and understand its rules and its customers.

- ☐ Re-read your three opportunities from Chapter 9 and choose the one that best fits your skills, money and risk tolerance.
- ☐ Write one sentence describing your customer: who they are, what they need, and why they would buy from you.
- ☐ Talk to at least ten potential customers or industry people. Ask what frustrates them and what they currently pay for.
- ☐ Visit at least three existing businesses doing something similar. Note prices, quality, packaging, service and how they sell.

- ☐ Identify which rules apply to your idea (Chapter 11) and contact the relevant authority to confirm the current requirements.
- ☐ Complete the "Your own numbers" table in Chapter 10 for your chosen idea.
- ☐ Sign up for a short course if your idea needs a skill you lack, such as gemstone identification, jewellery making or bookkeeping.

**Decision point at day 30:** if the numbers do not work or the rules are out of reach, go back to your list and choose another idea. Changing course now costs almost nothing.

## Days 31 to 60: Build connections

**Goal:** find credible suppliers, partners and early customers, and cost the idea properly.

- ☐ Meet at least five potential suppliers, makers or collaborators. Ask for registration, references and samples.
- ☐ Verify at least two of them independently (Chapter 11, Step 5).
- ☐ Attend an industry event, workshop or exhibition. Prepare your questions in advance and collect contact details of people you can follow up with.
- ☐ Get written quotes for materials, equipment, packaging, delivery and any registrations you need.
- ☐ Update your numbers with real quotes instead of guesses.
- ☐ Register your business name or company if you have not already, and register with SCUML if your activity requires it.
- ☐ Open a separate account for business money.

**Decision point at day 60:** can you deliver your offer at a price customers accept and still make a profit? If not, adjust the offer, the supplier or the customer.

## Days 61 to 90: Validate

**Goal:** run a small, legal, low-risk test and learn from real customers.

- ☐ Prepare a minimum offer: a small product range, a service package or a pilot batch.
- ☐ Take pre-orders or deposits where appropriate, so customers commit before you spend heavily on stock.
- ☐ Make your first sales to real customers outside your circle of friends and family.
- ☐ Ask every customer what they liked, what they would change, and what they would pay for next.
- ☐ Record every sale, cost and customer comment.
- ☐ Calculate your real revenue, costs, profit and cash position.
- ☐ Write a one-page summary of what you learned and decide: **continue, change, or stop.**

## What success looks like at day 90

Success is not a large profit. Success is clear evidence: a customer who paid, a supplier you trust, a set of real numbers, and a decision made from facts rather than hope. A person who ends ninety days knowing that this industry is not for her has still gained something real, because she has not spent a year finding out.

## Where Amaka might be

I will not invent Amaka's results. It would be dishonest to pretend that a composite character's three months would go well, and a book that tells you only success stories is not telling you the truth. What I can say is what a good outcome looks like for someone in her position: ten conversations with brides and designers, two suppliers visited and one verified, a first small batch pre-sold, honest numbers in a notebook, and a decision.

## Ground rules for your 90 days

- Never pay a stranger a large sum before seeing and testing the goods.
- Never invest money you cannot afford to lose.
- Never skip registrations because "everyone does".
- Keep a notebook of every conversation, quote and decision.
- Ask for help early. The people in industry associations and at events like GGCE have usually met the problem you are meeting.

CHAPTER 13

# Why You Must Be at GGCE

*One room, five days, and the people you cannot meet by reading*

A book can give you a map. It cannot give you a guide, a supplier, a mentor or a customer. Those come from people, and in this industry, people are found in rooms.

That is the case for the Gold & Gemstone Conference & Exhibition, and I will make it as plainly as I can. If you are serious about entering this industry, as a maker, a trader, a service provider or an investor, you need to be where the industry gathers. GGCE is a gathering built for exactly that purpose.

## How GGCE began

GGCE is a creation of Women in Mining in Nigeria. The organisation's own communique describes the first Lagos edition as the maiden edition and the first of its kind in the city, with the Lagos State Government taking part. It has returned every year since, and 2026 is its fifth edition. The 2024 edition was backed by Ecobank Nigeria, which announced a partnership with WIMIN for the conference. The 2025 edition, held in Lagos from 26 to 28 November, carried the theme "Accelerating Collaboration for Sustainable Gold and Gemstone Development in Africa" and was organised with the African Minerals Development Centre, an agency of the African Union.

Before that edition, the Minister of Solid Minerals Development publicly backed the event, saying it would feature technical sessions, mentorship programmes and practical workshops designed to bring more young people and women into the industry. In other words, this is not a trade fair in a hotel lobby. It sits where industry, policy and women's advancement meet.

## GGCE Lagos 2026 at a glance

| | |
|---|---|
| **Edition** | Fifth anniversary edition |
| **Dates** | 24 to 28 November 2026 |
| **Venue** | Lagos Oriental Hotel, Lagos |
| **Theme** | African Women Driving Africa's Gold and Gemstone Economy: Catalysing Investment, Innovation and Global Competitiveness |

Source: Daily Trust. Check the official GGCE channels for the final programme, as sessions and speakers may change.

According to published announcements, the 2026 edition will concentrate on moving beyond the export of raw minerals towards local value addition across mining, processing, jewellery manufacturing, technology, trading and design. The elements announced so far are:

- **Conference sessions** on the gold, gemstone and jewellery value chain.
- **Conversations and networking** on the growing role of African women as miners, processors, designers, manufacturers, traders, exporters, entrepreneurs, investors and leaders.
- **Awards and Recognition**, honouring outstanding women and other industry figures.
- **Jewellery-making masterclasses** for aspiring and established entrepreneurs.

- **An exhibition** of gold and gemstone products and services, as the event's full name (Conference & Exhibition) indicates. Confirm the details of the exhibition with the organisers.

WIMIN's president has said the 2026 edition will create stronger platforms for investment, skills development, women's participation, innovation and international collaboration.

## Six reasons to be there

I promised a reasoned case. Here it is.

**1. This industry runs on trust, and trust is built face to face.** Gold and gemstones are traded on reputation. A supplier you meet, whose work you can handle and whose references you can check, is worth more than ten you found online. An event concentrates in a few days what would otherwise take you years of travel.

**2. You will learn faster in a room than in a library.** The best questions in this industry have no textbook answer: Which supplier delivers as promised? What did the licence application actually require? How did you price your first collection? Masterclasses and conversations put those questions to people who have faced them.

**3. You will see what good looks like.** Reading about quality is different from holding it. A well-cut tourmaline, a well-finished chain, a well-made bridal set: seeing and touching work at its best resets your standards faster than any description.

**4. The conversation about the future of the industry happens here.** The 2026 theme speaks of investment, innovation and global competitiveness. If you want to understand where the sector is heading, which policies matter, and where money and training may flow, you want to hear the discussion directly.

**5. It is where women's participation is taken seriously.** Chapter 8 showed that women are central to this industry and under-recorded in it. GGCE was built by the organisation that has spent twenty years

addressing that, and this year its theme puts women at the centre. For a woman entering the industry, it is a gathering of people who understand your obstacles. For a man, it is a chance to learn how the industry works in practice.

**6. The timing is right.** A fifth edition. A government that has set up a gold buyer, announced training centres and put the sector on its agenda. A public worn thin by the cost of living. If there is a moment for an ordinary person to look seriously at this industry, this is a reasonable candidate.

## A caution, because I owe you one

Attending GGCE is not verification. Meeting someone at a conference does not prove that they are honest, licensed or capable. Everything in Chapter 11 still applies: verify before you pay, test before you buy, and write terms down. The event gives you access to people. Your judgment decides what to do with it.

It is also not a guarantee of anything. I cannot promise you business, contacts or income. I can only say that you are likelier to find them in a room full of the industry than outside it.

## How to use the five days

1. **Bring your three opportunities from Chapter 9** and decide which one you most want to test.
2. **Write your questions in advance.** Where do you buy your materials, and how do you verify them? Which rules surprised you? What do first-year customers need that new businesses overlook?
3. **Decide who you want to meet.** Suppliers, makers, buyers, trainers, service providers and officials are useful in different ways.
4. **Prepare a two-sentence introduction:** who you are, what you are exploring, and what help you are looking for.
5. **Carry a way to share your details,** such as a card, a WhatsApp business profile or a portfolio link.

6. **Listen more than you speak on the first day.** Learn who is who before you pitch.
7. **Take notes and follow up within a week.** Most connections are made after the event, not during it.
8. **Verify before you commit.** Apply Chapter 11 to everyone you do business with.

## Amaka decides

Amaka read this far with her calculator beside her. She did not stop worrying about the price of food. She did not suddenly believe that gold would save her. What changed was smaller and more useful. She had a list of three ideas, a way of testing them, an understanding of the rules, and a reason to go and meet the people who already know.

She registered.

## Join us

GGCE Lagos 2026 takes place from 24 to 28 November 2026 at the Lagos Oriental Hotel, Lagos. Registration details are available through the official GGCE channels.

If you have read this book carefully, you already know more about the industry than most Nigerians. The next step is to meet the people who can turn that knowledge into a first customer, a first supplier and a first test.

**GGCE Lagos 2026: Come Meet the Industry.**

EPILOGUE

# Look Down

We began with Amaka and her calculator, and with a question Nigerians are not asking: what else is under our feet?

You now have enough to answer it honestly. Under our feet are gold and gemstones, and a chain of businesses that turns them into jewellery, income and, sometimes, a good living. Behind us is a mining economy that Nigeria once had and let fade, from 5.6% of GDP in 1980 to a sliver of one percent four decades later. Around us is an informal sector that nobody has fully counted, full of women whose work is seldom recorded. Ahead of us is a moment of official attention that may or may not last, and that no one should bet their savings on.

I have not told you that this industry will rescue you from the economic crunch. It will not rescue anyone. What I have told you is that it is a place where a skilled person, with modest capital, a clear head and respect for the law, can look for a foothold. That is a smaller claim than the advertisements make, and it is a truer one.

The crunch is real, and the temptation in hard times is to grab the first dramatic promise. The discipline in hard times is the opposite: to look carefully, test small, follow the rules and learn from people who have done it. Do that, and whether or not this industry becomes yours, you will have made better decisions than most.

Five ideas to carry with you:

1. **You do not have to own a mine.** The chain from rough material to finished jewellery has many points of entry.

2. **Match the opportunity to you.** Your skills, savings and tolerance for risk decide where you start.
3. **Revenue is not profit.** Know your numbers before you spend.
4. **Follow the rules.** Mineral titles, trading permits and SCUML registration exist for good reasons. Verify before you pay.
5. **Test small, then grow.** Ninety days of honest testing is worth more than a year of planning.

For most of our history, we have been told to look at one thing. This book asks you to look down.

**GGCE Lagos 2026, 24 to 28 November 2026, Lagos Oriental Hotel. Come Meet the Industry.** Registration details are available through the official GGCE channels.

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## Your Notebook

## Your Notebook

# THE MILLION NAIRA OPPORTUNITY

***Look down.***

Nigerians are feeling the squeeze, while a whole mineral economy beneath our feet goes largely ignored. Tin, columbite and coal once made Nigeria a significant producer. Today the gold, the gemstones and the jewellery chain beyond them offer entry points for makers, traders, designers and service providers.

This guide explains how the industry fits together, where women have always been at its centre, what the law requires, and how to test an opportunity in ninety days, with every fact sourced and no invented statistics.

***You do not have to own a mine. You do need to know where the opportunities are.***

## GGCE LAGOS 2026

24–28 November 2026
Lagos Oriental Hotel, Lagos

*Come Meet the Industry*




*Registration details are available through the official GGCE channels.*

**GGCE LAGOS 2026**